

tale. For example, while investigating a mysterious old house the characters discover a diary kept by the original owner, a changeling who died mysteriously 100 years ago. Using the diary as the framework, the Storyteller turns the clock back one century and hands out new characters to the players, and for the next chapter or two they play out key scenes described in the diary in order to learn what happened. Perhaps it's even their characters' past lives, which makes it even more interesting if they find out one of them was actually the killer....

Unreliable Narration

Perhaps one of the trickiest of all techniques to pull off, but amazing when executed well, unreliable narration centers around one or more characters receiving descriptions that don't match "reality" as far as the game world is concerned. Naturally, characters who are descending into madness or Bedlam make good subjects for this technique, though it can also be used to create unsettling dream experiences and the like. A good cinematic example of this technique is the film *A Beautiful Mind*, where it is ultimately revealed that many events and even whole characters existed only in the main character's mind. Given the group-oriented nature of gaming, this sort of unreliable information filter can be quite tricky to arrange without potentially confusing the other players. The Storyteller is therefore advised to make the unreliable perspective public knowledge to the players, if not their characters; alternatively, she may keep it a secret either from the subject (but let the rest of the group in on it to enlist their help) or the group (so that only the subject knows).

The Prelude

Before introducing a player's character to the rest of the group and the chronicle proper, many Storytellers like to run a short introduction called a prelude. A prelude may consist of a single scene, or it may be an entire session. Often the prelude is private, played out as a one-on-one session between each player and the Storyteller, though it can be a full group session as well. Some Storytellers like to run individual scenes that eventually wind up bringing the group together, weaving the characters into each other's lives a bit more naturally than the classic "so one night you all just happen to be hanging around a bar" setup.

Regardless of how they are set up, prelude sessions offer some valuable elements to any chronicle. Think of the prelude as the "hook" for the story, the scene that both captures the attention of the audience as well as introduces the main character at the same time. A good prelude lets a character stretch her legs a bit and show off some of her nature, while also including potential story hooks and plot elements that will resurface later on.

Another useful aspect of the prelude is that it allows the Storyteller an extra opportunity to make sure the characters have a reason to stick together and, if not trust each other completely, at least not have so much mutual distrust it strains belief to have them keep associating with each other. A collective prelude makes this task a bit easier, but even individual ones can work with enough advance planning.

A Chrysalis Introduction

Running the Chrysalis as a prelude scene is an excellent way to introduce the setting to players who are new to **Changeling** — their characters are just as ignorant about the world of the fae as they are, and so they can ask questions and learn on both levels at once. This can alleviate some new player anxiety, as well as let her see exactly what it's like to step out of a mundane life for the first time and take in the chimerical world in all its glory.

Storytelling the Prelude

As a Storyteller, it is often useful to look at the prelude as a way of establishing a "baseline" for a character's life before the events of the chronicle intrude. After all, it's a lot harder for events to seem extraordinary unless a player has an idea of what is "ordinary" in the first place, so using the prelude to provide a sense of what is "normal" for a character makes spectacular and unusual events that much more impressive later on.

Of course, "normal" should not be confused for "boring" — even if the prelude is going to focus on the Chrysalis and accompanying transition from mortal to Kithain life, that doesn't mean it should be an hour spent roleplaying filling out tedious paperwork before the action begins! Rather, in the prelude a certain amount of normalcy should be put on display so the player can get a feel for what her character's life is like before the events of the chronicle turn it upside down.

Preludes are an excellent time to give players a preview of the themes and moods that will be prevalent in the chronicle. For example, if a chronicle theme is "hope is fragile," rather than dash a character's hopes directly, the Storyteller could feature some hopes being broken in the background of a character's prelude, such as a character overhearing a couple lose their homes to foreclosure while waiting in a bank. Moments like that allow the theme to be introduced without putting it front and center in the character's life, while being notable enough to make an impression.

Preludes are also excellent places to employ other advanced narrative techniques as well, particularly foreshadowing. If the Storyteller has even some vague ideas about characters or events that might be introduced in the future, planting hints and making references to such elements makes them even more effective later on, since they don't crop up out of nowhere but date all the way back to the beginning of the chronicle.

Playing the Prelude

Coming from a player's point of view, the prelude offers valuable time to try out a role and start to understand her point of view, come up with a "voice" for her when roleplaying, and otherwise tinker with various aspects of character portrayal. This is especially true if the prelude is being handled as a pri-